

RED-BELLIED PIRANHAS "BARK" TO WARN OFF OTHER FISH



KEY

 Red-bellied piranha range

Steady waters
Red-bellied piranhas prefer the lower section of rivers, which are wider, deeper, and move more slowly. They are less likely to be found in the narrower and faster-flowing sections nearer the river's source.

White waters
Most red-bellied piranhas live in the cloudier, sediment-heavy "white waters" closer to the Amazon's mouth, where the river drains into the Atlantic.

Shoaling

Piranhas are often feared as blood-thirsty fish that attack big prey in frenzied shoals. But studies have shown that shoaling, as with other fish species, is more a way of protecting themselves from predators. Plenty of Amazon animals, such as giant otters, eat piranhas as prey.



Carnivorous fish

Found in rivers, streams, lakes, and flooded forests, the red-bellied piranha is known for its vicious appetite. In reality it usually hunts fish and other small aquatic animals, and avoids anything bigger. Only in the dry season, when pools run low and hungry piranhas are forced together, may piranhas attack bigger land animals that stumble into the waters.

Red-bellied piranha

The rivers running through the Amazon Basin in northern South America are home to the biggest diversity of freshwater fish in the world, including 38 species of piranha. Among them is the red-bellied piranha—a fish with a fearsome reputation.



Red bellies
This species is recognizable for its red belly and silvery body.